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AS PART OF NATIONAL CRIME VICTIMS' RIGHTS WEEK, ATTORNEY GENERAL BONTA HIGHLIGHTS RESOURCES TO SUPPORT VICTIMS AND SURVIVORS

April 26, 2024 | US Fed News (USA)
598 Words
OpenURL Link

SACRAMENTO, Calif., April 26 -- The California Attorney General issued the following press release:

OAKLAND- As part of National Crime Victims' Rights Week, California Attorney General Rob Bonta today highlighted resources available through the California Department of Justice's (DOJ) Victims' Services Unit (VSU), and through additional outlets to support and empower victims, survivors, and their families. Attorney General Bonta urges service providers and all members of the public to use these resources to help ensure all those who have been the victim of a crime are aware of many of the key rights, resources, and protections available to them in California.

"Victims of crime often struggle to rebuild their lives, and so, it is incumbent on all of us - in particular those of us in positions of power - to have their backs,"said Attorney General Bonta. "At the California Department of Justice, we are shining a light on the life-saving resources available to those who have been impacted by crime. During National Crime Victims' Rights Week and all year round, my office will continue to lead with compassion and offer crime victims the support that they deserve.

California DOJ Victims' Services Unit

VSU works to provide victim-centered, trauma-informed, and culturally sensitive support services tocrime victims, including underserved, at-risk, underrepresented, and vulnerable populations. Through the unit's services, victims can track the status of appeals, recusal cases, and other matters being handled by DOJ's prosecutors. VSU has a dedicated and well-trained team of advocates who provide appeal notifications to victims and their families. These updates allow victims and their families to exercise their rights to address the court or otherwise participate in criminal justice proceedings.Our newly revised Marsy's Card aims to empower victims and survivors by advising them of their rights as victims of crime, and provide updated resources available to them.

VSU also supports service providers and members of the public in tracking the progress of sexual assault evidence kits as they are processed both at the state and local level through the Sexual Assault Forensic Evidence Tracking (SAFE-T database). Importantly, VSU's advocates work to help victims and their families access available resources that are a critical part of the healing process, such as mental health services, safety net services, and assistance through the California Victim Compensation Board for related crime expenses.VSU's latest Sexual Assault Survivor's Bill ofRights publication provides resources and supports available, tailored to sexual assault victims and survivors.

VSU has updated publications for crime victims in an effort to provide comprehensive resources and supports tailored to their needs.TheMarsy's Rights Card,Appeals brochure,Sexual Assault Survivor's Bill of Rights, and theVictims' Services Unit brochureoffer information and resources to crime victims.

Additional Resources Available for Victims

Attorney General Bonta is committed to protecting all victims of crime and violence. On February 8, 2024, heurgedCongress to provide critical support and services to victims and survivors of crime by taking steps to increase the Crime Victims Fund with short term, bridge funding. On April 9, 2024, he announced hissponsorship of a billauthored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) and joint authored by Assemblymember Eloise Gómez Reyes (D-Colton) that would allow state courts to levy increased monetary penalties on corporations convicted of criminal offenses. Such penalties would in turn provide much-needed funding for crime victim service programs in California.

To receive information on resources, notification of an appeal, or notification on a case the Attorney General's Office is prosecuting, visitoag.ca.gov/victimservices, call VSU at (877) 433-9069,orcontactVSUatoag.ca.gov/victimservices/contact.To learn more about the work of VSU, please watch ourDemystifying the DOJ Presentation on the Victims' Services Unit.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  AS PART OF NATIONAL CRIME VICTIMS' RIGHTS WEEK, ATTORNEY GENERAL BONTA HIGHLIGHTS RESOURCES TO SUPPORT VICTIMS AND SURVIVORS. (2024, April 26). *US Fed News (USA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/198D301C5C65A740.